



Aspirational surge: A world title behind her, Harmanpreet Kaur stands before schoolchildren who no longer have to imagine what a women's cricket hero looks like. B. VELANKANNIRAJ

180 million people globally followed the tournament, creating fertile ground for advertisers. In India alone, 156 million watched the event, including 80 million from rural areas, and the final drew 126 million viewers. India's performances contributed to a fivefold increase in viewing hours. The ICC reported a threefold jump compared to the 2013 edition.

Advertising gigs, sponsorship deals and endorsements followed. Meanwhile, marketing and licensing companies like Baseline Ventures began tapping the potential of female athletes in brand spaces.

"When I co-founded Baseline, we wanted to look at sports beyond men's cricket, which was the low-hanging fruit because everyone was in that space. So we started looking at a lot of non-cricket, non-men's cricket sports," says Tuhin Mishra, CEO of Baseline ventures.

Double Olympic medallist P. V.

Sindhu was one of the company's first signings around 2015, long before she amassed her biggest accolades.

"Nearly 70 per cent of our representation roster is female. Even within cricket, we understood that women's cricket needs to be seen as its own entity, or its true value can never be unlocked. The vertical and the athletes need to stand on their own," Tuhin adds.

Baseline signed Smriti Mandhana after the 2017 World Cup, seeing in the then 21-year-old the potential to become one of the most recognisable faces in global cricket in the decade ahead.

"She broke the glass ceiling not just on the field, but also in entering categories that were deemed to be male-dominated, and much of this was set in motion before the World Cup. She had ended up with long-term deals with Gulf Oil (which had M. S. Dhoni as its face), SBI Bank, Herbalife, and PNB MetLife — all

predominantly carrying a male star's brand value until then.

"Most brands come in on a transactional basis, when big events happen or when a World Cup like this comes along. People need to realise that this game is like the stock market. You need to be in it for the long haul to truly draw out the real value."

In 2024, SportsPro featured only two cricketers among its 150 most marketable global faces: Virat Kohli and Smriti, a significant endorsement of women's cricket in the branding space.

Cash cow

The Women's Premier League cemented the sport's commercial viability. The BCCI received a record Rs. 4,669.99 crore (USD 575 million) from auctioning the league's five franchises to the Adani Group, Reliance, Diageo India, the JSW GMR joint venture, and Capri Global. By